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United States Patent	12404660
Kind Code	B2
Date of Patent	September 02, 2025
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Dispersible wear indicator

Abstract

A wear member includes an attachment portion, and a wear portion extending from the attachment portion that defines a wear surface. The wear portion has a dispersible wear indicator that is disposed in the wear portion, and that is spaced a predetermined distance away from the wear surface.

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Appl. No.: 17/723732

Filed: April 19, 2022

Prior Publication Data

Document Identifier	Publication Date
US 20230332382 A1	Oct. 19, 2023

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: E02F9/26 (20060101); E02F9/28 (20060101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC E02F9/2883 (20130101); E02F9/26 (20130101); E02F9/2858 (20130101); E02F9/2833 (20130101)

Field of Classification Search

CPC: E02F (9/2883); E02F (9/26); E02F (9/2858); E02F (9/2833); E02F (9/2808)

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Background/Summary

TECHNICAL FIELD

(1) The present disclosure relates to wear members attached to the work implements of heavy equipment such as cold planers, bulldozers, mining equipment, and the like. Specifically, the present disclosure relates to wear members that have wear indicators.

BACKGROUND

(2) In industries such as the earthmoving, mining, construction, paving, and agriculture industries, etc., work implements such as buckets, blades, shovels, grapples, shears, etc. have ground engaging tools such as shrouds, sliders or skids, cutting edges, etc. are used to encounter a work material such as rocks, dirt, asphalt, etc. In general the ground engaging tools and other wear members are attached to provide a buffer between the work material and the work implement to extend the useful life of the work implement. At some point in time, the wear member is worn away and needs to be replaced.

(3) U.S. Pat. Appl. Publ. No. 2011/0162241 A1 discloses a wear indicator on a tool that is provided to determine if a blade or edge of a tool is worn past a predetermined point. It provides for the easy identification of the condition of replacement wear surfaces. The wear indicator or marking may be implemented in many ways that will not interfere or impede in the integrity of the blade or tool. Some examples include laser etching of the mark, a line pressed into the surface of the blade,

dimples along a line, a scribe mark, a paint, a material located inside of the product that becomes visible when the part is to be replaced, or any other suitable way to easily and visually determine the condition of the blade.

(4) These known wear indicators require the operator of a machine using such work tools or wear members to visually inspect the wear member to determine its condition. This may require machine downtime, or even disassembly of the equipment in order to see the wear indicator. For example, cold planer attachments used with paving equipment cannot always be seen during use since they are obstructed by various components of the cold planer attachment. This may require disassembly of the attachment in order to see the condition of the wear indicators, necessitating a prolonged amount of downtime for the machine which is undesirable for an economic endeavor employing the machine.

(5) Accordingly, wear indicators that may be observed without requiring machine downtime are needed.

SUMMARY

(6) A wear member according to an embodiment of the present disclosure includes an attachment portion, and a wear portion extending from the attachment portion that defines a wear surface. The wear portion may have a bleeding wear indicator that is disposed in the wear portion, and that is spaced a predetermined distance away from the wear surface.

(7) A skid for use with a cold planer assembly according to an embodiment of the present disclosure may comprise a sliding portion including a sliding surface, and a connecting portion extending from the sliding portion that is thinner than the sliding portion. The sliding portion may include a first dispersible wear indicator positioned in the sliding portion away from the sliding surface.

(8) A method of alerting that a wear member needs to be replaced according to an embodiment of the present disclosure may comprise forming a wear member that includes a dispersible wear indicator or a bleeding wear indicator.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) The accompanying drawings, which are incorporated in and constitute a part of this specification, illustrate several embodiments of the disclosure and together with the description, serve to explain the principles of the disclosure. In the drawings:

(2) FIG. 1 illustrates a machine in the form of a cold planer with a cold planer attachment assembly having wear members with a bleeding wear indicator constructed according to the various embodiments disclosed herein.

(3) FIG. 2 is a perspective view of the cold planer attachment assembly of FIG. 1 with its front portion removed, revealing wear members such as skids or sliders that use a bleeding wear indicator according to an embodiment of the present disclosure.

(4) FIG. 3 illustrates the cold planer attachment assembly of FIG. 2 with more components removed, revealing more wear members such as skids or sliders that use a bleeding wear indicator according to various embodiments of the present disclosure.

(5) FIG. 4 is an enlarged detail view of a wear member attached to the assembly of FIG. 3.

(6) FIG. 5 is a perspective view of the wear member of FIG. 4 shown in isolation.

(7) FIG. 6 is a perspective view of another embodiment of a heel shroud similar or identical to that of FIG. 3 except that durability enhancements are added such as chocky bars or the like.

(8) FIG. 7 contains a flowchart depicting a method of use according to an embodiment of the present disclosure.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(9) Reference will now be made in detail to embodiments of the disclosure, examples of which are illustrated in the accompanying drawings. Wherever possible, the same reference numbers will be used throughout the drawings to refer to the same or like parts. In some cases, a reference number will be indicated in this specification and the drawings will show the reference number followed by a letter for example, 100a, 100b etc. It is to be understood that the use of letters immediately after a reference number indicates that these features are similarly shaped and have similar function as is often the case when geometry is mirrored about a plane of symmetry. For ease of explanation in this specification, letters will often not be included herein but may be shown in the drawings to indicate duplications of features discussed within this written specification.

(10) While the arrangement is illustrated in connection with a cold planer attachment assembly being used by a skid steer, the arrangement disclosed herein has universal applicability in various other types of machines commonly employ track systems, as well wheels. The term “machine” may refer to any machine that performs some type of operation associated with an industry such as mining, earthmoving, or construction, paving, or any other industry known in the art. For example, the machine may be a skid steer as shown, a paver, an excavator, a wheel loader, a cable shovel, or a dragline or the like. Moreover, one or more implements may be connected to the machine. Such implements may be utilized for a variety of tasks, including, for example, lifting, loading, pushing and paving.

(11) FIG. 1 illustrates an exemplary machine **100** having multiple systems and components that cooperate to accomplish a task. Machine **100** may embody a mobile machine that performs some type of operation associated with an industry such as mining, construction, farming or agriculture, transportation, earth moving, or any other known industry. For example, machine **100** may be a milling machine such as a cold planer. Machine **100** may include a power source **102** and one or more undercarriage assembly **104**, which may be driven by power source **102**.

(12) Power source **102** may drive the undercarriage assembly(s) **104** of machine **100** at a range of output speeds and torques. Power source **102** may be an engine such as, for example, a diesel engine, a gasoline engine, a gaseous fuel-powered engine, or any other suitable engine. Power source **102** may also be a non-combustion source of power such as, for example, a fuel cell, a power storage device, or any other source of power known in the art.

(13) Undercarriage assembly(s) **104** may include crawler tracks **106**. The undercarriage assemblies **104** may be attached to the machine **100** via hydraulic cylinders **108** that may be raised or lowered or rotated to position the machine **100** vertically and/or horizontally at a desired position relative to a work surface. Other types of undercarriages may be employed such as those employing wheels, walking mechanisms, etc.

(14) An implement assembly in the form of a cold planer attachment assembly **200**, which includes a rotary cutting drum assembly or ripping subassembly **204** (best seen in FIG. 2), is shown to be attached to and extend from the bottom of the machine **100** in FIG. 1 such that it can hover a desired distance above the work surface. The implement assembly **110** includes two hydraulic side plates **114** (see FIG. 2) with position sensors (not shown) used to monitor and position the rotary cutting drum assembly or ripping subassembly **204** (shown in FIG. 2). A cover plate **201** (see FIG. 2) extending between the side plates **114** is often employed to partially surround the rotary cutting drum assembly **112**, being positioned above and to the rear of the cutting drum. A transmission (not shown) may be operatively connected to the power source **102** and the rotary cutting drum assembly or ripping subassembly, allowing the power source **102** to drive the rotary cutting drum assembly or ripping subassembly to rotate and rip up the work surface.

(15) As shown in FIG. 2, the cold planer attachment assembly **200** is fitted with hydraulic hoses **116** to feed water that is sprayed onto the rotary cutting drum assembly or ripping subassembly **204**, helping to remove debris from the vicinity in use. This debris is diverted by the machine **100** to a foldable conveyor system **118** (see FIG. 1) that transports the material to another vehicle or dump site where the discarded material is hauled away from the work area.

(16) In FIG. 1, a cab **120** is also shown that houses a seat **122** and controls **124** for the operator to use to control the various functions of the machine **100**. For example, the operator may use these controls to manipulate the assembly **200** for ripping up pavement such as asphalt as shown, paving, pushing material, digging, excavating, or any other suitable application. The configuration of this machine as well as the cold planer attachment assembly **200** may be varied as needed or desired. The machine of FIG. 1 is provided by way of an example only as other types of machines are considered to be within the scope of the present disclosure. For example, a cold planer attachment assembly **200** may be used by a skid steer, etc.

(17) Looking at FIGS. 2 thru 4, the cold planer attachment assembly is shown in progressively greater detail, with various components of the assembly removed to aid the reader in understanding its construction, and the wear members (e.g., skids) that may have a wear indicator constructed according to various embodiments of the present disclosure.

(18) FIG. 2 has the front portion removed, revealing a blade like structure **202** with skids **300** that are positioned in front of the ripping subassembly **204** that may have bits (not shown) for ripping up paved surfaces such as asphalt, concrete, etc. A hydraulic motor **206** may rotate a drum (not shown) on which the bits are attached to rip up the paved surface. The skids **300** may contact the work surface or the paved surface and are prone to wear. The skids may be attached to the blade like structure or other frame members of the assembly via welding, fastening (as shown in FIGS. 3 and 4), etc.

(19) Referring to FIG. 3, a pair of skids **300**, **300a** are shown to be attached to the blade like structure. Similarly or identically configured skids **300b**, **300c**, **300d**, **300e**, etc. to those just described are also attached to a bottom frame member(s) **208** that is attached to the front panel **210** of the ripping subassembly **204**.

(20) An instance of a skid **300c** is best shown in FIG. 4 as being attached to a bottom frame member **208** using fasteners **212**. Wear indicators **302** are shown that may indicate to an operator or other personnel in the work area that the skid needs to be replaced as will be discussed in more detail later herein.

(21) Turning now to FIGS. 5 and 6, various embodiments of a skid (and in a more general sense a wear member) that have one or more wear indicators will be described now in detail.

(22) The skid **300** may comprise a sliding portion **304** including a sliding surface **306** (i.e., a bottom surface that contacts or slides on the work material such as asphalt, etc.), as well as a connecting portion **308** that may extend from the sliding portion **304**, and that is thinner than the sliding portion **304**.

(23) More specifically, the connecting portion **308** (which may also be referred to as an attachment portion since this portion is used to attach the skid or wear member to some other structure via fasteners inserted through a plurality of thru-holes **317**, via welding, etc.) may define an attachment portion width **W308**, while the sliding portion **304** (which may also be referred to as a wear portion since this portion wears as this portion slides) defines a wear portion width **W304** that is greater than the attachment portion width **W308**.

(24) This may yield an at least partially "T shape" **309** in a cross-section parallel to the wear portion width **W304** and the attachment portion width **W308**. As shown in FIG. 5, the attachment portion (or connecting portion **308**) may be disposed at a midpoint **310** along the wear portion width **W304**. This may not be the case for other embodiments of the present disclosure.

(25) The sliding portion **304** may include a first dispersible wear indicator **302** (may also be referred to as a bleeding wear indicator since the substance from which the wear indicator is made may bleed or leach into the working material, etc.) positioned in the sliding portion **304** away from the sliding surface **306** as represented by distance **311**. More particularly, the first dispersible wear indicator **302** may have an elongated racetrack perimeter **312** (so called since the perimeter has two flat sides that are joined by semicircles), but not necessarily so. For example, other shaped perimeters may be employed including rectangular, circular, elliptical, polynomial, etc. In some

embodiments, the first dispersible wear indicator comprises at least one of the following: a paint, a polymer, a dissolvable solid, and a fluid, etc.

(26) Also, a ramp portion **314** may be provided that extends from the sliding portion **304** at an oblique angle **316** to the sliding portion **304**. This ramp portion may also be referred to as a “push portion”, a “deflector portion”, etc. as it moves material or debris out of the way of the skid, underneath the skid, etc. So, the ramp portion may include a bottom surface that acts as a push surface **318**.

(27) With continued reference to FIGS. **5** and **6**, the ramp portion may include a second dispersible wear indicator **302a** that is disposed in the ramp portion **314**, and that is spaced away from the push surface **318** in a similar manner as the first dispersible wear indicator **302** is spaced a predetermined distance **311** away from the sliding surface **306**. This may not be the case for other embodiments of the present disclosure.

(28) Also, the sliding portion **304** may include a top exposed surface **322** (may be planar and parallel to the sliding surface **306**), and the first dispersible wear indicator **302** may be disposed at the top exposed surface **322** of the sliding portion **304** proximate to the connecting portion **308** (or attachment portion). For example, the wear indicator may be disposed inside of the sliding portion or wear portion away from any exposed surface, etc.

(29) To provide ease and flexibility in use and during assembly, the first dispersible wear indicator **302** may be symmetrical to the second dispersible wear indicator **302a** about a first plane of symmetry **324** as shown in FIG. **6**. In addition as shown in FIG. **5**, the skid **300** may further comprise a third dispersible wear indicator **302b**, and a fourth dispersible wear indicator (not shown in FIGS. **5** and **6** but understood to be present by looking at FIG. **4**) that are symmetrical to the first dispersible wear indicator **302**, and the second wear indicator **302a** about a second plane of symmetry **326**. Consequently, the ramp portion may become the sliding portion, and the left side may become the right side, depending on how the user attaches the skid **300** to the assembly **200** without changing the desired performances. One or more symmetries may not be present in other embodiments of the present disclosure.

(30) In a more general sense, the skid **300** may be referred to as a wear member and its construction or associated principles may be applied to other types of wear members such as shrouds, tips, and cutting edges, etc.

(31) Still referring to FIGS. **5** and **6**, a wear member (e.g., skid **300**) may comprise an attachment portion (e.g., see **308**), and a wear portion (e.g., see **304**) extending from the attachment portion that defines a working surface or a wear surface (may take the form of a sliding surface **306** or another surface that contacts a work material such as asphalt, dirt, rocks, etc.). A bleeding wear indicator (e.g., see **302**) may be disposed in the wear portion, and may be spaced a predetermined distance **311** away from the wear surface.

(32) As alluded to earlier herein, the bleeding or dispersible wear indicator may comprise at least one of the following: a paint, a polymer, a dissolvable solid, and a fluid etc.

(33) In certain embodiments, the bleeding wear indicator includes a fluid that comprises at least one of the following: a colored liquid, and a colored gas. When the working material contacts or exposes the liquid or gas, the liquid may be seen on the work material, or the gas may be seen in the vicinity of the work area, alerting the operator or other personnel in the area that a wear member needs to be replaced.

(34) In other embodiments the bleeding or dispersible wear indicator may include a dissolvable solid that is water soluble. When the working material contacts the dissolvable solid, the moisture content of the working material (e.g., as would be the case for oilsands applications) will cause the solid to disperse or bleed into the working material, alerting that a wear member needs to be repaired or replaced.

(35) In some embodiments, the bleeding or dispersible wear indicator includes a paint that is yellow, or a polymer that is yellow. Other noticeable colors may be employed including red,

orange, etc.

(36) As depicted in FIGS. 5 and 6, the bleeding or dispersible wear indicator (e.g., see **302**, **302a**, **302b**, **302b**) may be disposed nearer the attachment portion (e.g., see **308**) as opposed to the wear surface (e.g., see **306**). The opposite may be true in other embodiments of the present disclosure.

(37) The skid or wear member may be a unitary body as shown or be an assembly of different parts including enhanced wear members (e.g., chocky blocks, wear buttons, etc.), mounting plates, etc. Often, the skid or wear member consists essentially of a metallic material such as cast iron, steel, grey cast iron, etc.

(38) Any of the aforementioned features and their associated dimensions may be altered to be different than what has been shown or mentioned herein in other embodiments of the present disclosure.

INDUSTRIAL APPLICABILITY

(39) In practice, a work implement, a skid, and/or a wear member or a portion thereof may be sold, manufactured, bought etc. and attached to the machine in the aftermarket or original equipment scenarios according to any of the embodiments discussed herein. That is to say, the machine may be sold with the work implement, a skid, and/or a wear member and/or a portion thereof according to embodiments described herein or the machine may be retrofitted, repaired, refurbished to use any of the embodiments discussed herein. The various components including, but not limited to the skids, may be fabricated from any suitable material such as cast iron, grey cast iron, steel, etc.

(40) FIG. 7 discloses a method **400** of alerting an operator that a wear member needs to be replaced that may comprise the following steps: forming a wear member that includes a dispersible wear indicator or a bleeding wear indicator (step **402**); and using the wear member until a work material contacts the dispersible wear indicator or the bleeding wear indicator, releasing a dispersing material or bleeding material that can be seen on the work material, or in air (step **404**).

(41) In some embodiments, the bleeding or dispersing material may comprise a liquid that will glow when ultraviolet light is shown on it (may be referred to as a “UV glowing liquid” (step **406**). To that end, UV lights **126** may be supplied at the rear of the machine as shown in FIG. 1 so that the liquid will glow and be seen behind the machine.

(42) The nature of this dispersible or bleeding material allows it to be left behind or to egress away from a hidden wear member, giving notice that the wear member may need servicing without necessitating disassembly of the machine, or assembly to which the hidden wear member is attached. This may avoid unnecessary downtime for the machine.

(43) As used herein, the articles “a” and “an” are intended to include one or more items, and may be used interchangeably with “one or more.” Where only one item is intended, the term “one” or similar language is used. Also, as used herein, the terms “has”, “have”, “having”, “with” or the like are intended to be open-ended terms. Further, the phrase “based on” is intended to mean “based, at least in part, on” unless explicitly stated otherwise.

(44) It will be apparent to those skilled in the art that various modifications and variations can be made to the embodiments of the apparatus and methods of assembly as discussed herein without departing from the scope or spirit of the invention(s). Other embodiments of this disclosure will be apparent to those skilled in the art from consideration of the specification and practice of the various embodiments disclosed herein. For example, some of the equipment may be constructed and function differently than what has been described herein and certain steps of any method may be omitted, performed in an order that is different than what has been specifically mentioned or in some cases performed simultaneously or in sub-steps. Furthermore, variations or modifications to certain aspects or features of various embodiments may be made to create further embodiments and features and aspects of various embodiments may be added to or substituted for other features or aspects of other embodiments in order to provide still further embodiments.

(45) Accordingly, it is intended that the specification and examples be considered as exemplary

only, with a true scope and spirit of the invention(s) being indicated by the following claims and their equivalents.

Claims

1. A wear member comprising: an attachment portion; a wear portion extending from the attachment portion that defines a wear surface; and a bleeding wear indicator disposed in the wear portion and spaced a predetermined distance away from the wear surface, wherein the bleeding wear indicator comprises a dissolvable solid, the dissolvable solid dispersing to a working material upon contacting moisture in the working material to indicate that the wear member needs to be repaired or replaced.
2. The wear member of claim 1, wherein the bleeding wear indicator further comprises at least one of: a paint, a polymer, or a fluid.
3. The wear member of claim 2, wherein the fluid comprises at least one: a UV glowing liquid, or a colored gas visible in a vicinity of a work area upon exposure indicating the wear member needing to be repaired or replaced.
4. The wear member of claim 1, wherein the bleeding wear indicator is disposed nearer the attachment portion as opposed to the wear surface.
5. The wear member of claim 1, wherein the attachment portion defines an attachment portion width, and the wear portion defines a wear portion width that is greater than the attachment portion width.
6. The wear member of claim 5, wherein the wear member has an at least partially “T shape” in a cross-section parallel to the wear portion width and the attachment portion width.
7. The wear member of claim 5, wherein the attachment portion is disposed at a midpoint along the wear portion width.
8. A skid for use with a cold planer assembly, the skid comprising: a sliding portion including a sliding surface; a connecting portion extending from the sliding portion that is thinner than the sliding portion; and a first dispersible wear indicator disposed in the sliding portion and positioned away from the sliding surface, wherein the first dispersible wear indicator comprises a dissolvable solid, the dissolvable solid dispersing to a working material upon contacting moisture in the working material to indicate that the skid needs to be replaced.
9. The skid of claim 8, further comprising a ramp portion extending from the sliding portion at an oblique angle to the sliding portion.
10. The skid of claim 9, wherein the ramp portion includes a second dispersible wear indicator that is disposed in the ramp portion.
11. The skid of claim 10, wherein the ramp portion includes a push surface, and the second dispersible wear indicator is spaced away from the push surface.
12. The skid of claim 8, wherein the sliding portion includes a top exposed surface, and the first dispersible wear indicator is disposed at the top exposed surface of the sliding portion proximate to the connecting portion.
13. The skid of claim 9, wherein the first dispersible wear indicator has an elongated racetrack perimeter.
14. The skid of claim 9, wherein the first dispersible wear indicator further comprises at least one: a paint, a polymer, a fluid.
15. The skid of claim 9, wherein the connecting portion includes a plurality of thru-holes.
16. The skid of claim 10, wherein: the first dispersible wear indicator is symmetrical to the second dispersible wear indicator about a first plane of symmetry, and the skid further comprises a third dispersible wear indicator and a fourth dispersible wear indicator, the third dispersible wear indicator and the fourth dispersible wear indicator being symmetrical to the first dispersible wear indicator and the second dispersible wear indicator about a second plane of symmetry.

17. The skid of claim 16, wherein the second dispersible wear indicator comprises one of: a paint, a polymer, a dissolvable solid, or a fluid.

18. The skid of claim 16, wherein the third dispersible wear indicator comprises: a UV glowing liquid dispersing to the working material upon contacting the working material to indicate under UV lights that the wear member needs to be replaced, or a colored gas visible in a vicinity of a work area upon exposure indicating the wear member needing to be repaired or replaced.

19. A method of alerting that a wear member needs to be replaced comprising: forming a wear member that includes a bleeding wear indicator, wherein the bleeding wear indicator comprises a dissolvable solid, the dissolvable solid dispersing to a working material upon contacting moisture in the working material to indicate that the wear member needs to be replaced.

20. The method of claim 19, wherein the wear member further includes a dispersible wear indicator, the method further comprising: upon the work material contacting the dispersible wear indicator, releasing a dispersing material visible in a vicinity of a work area.

21. The method of claim 20, further comprising using ultraviolet light to cause a liquid acting as the dispersing material or the bleeding material to glow.
